Manchester United 2021: Solving the Wrong Problem

A data-led counterfactual on output vs control in squad-building decisions

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1. THE DIAGNOSIS

In 2021, Manchester United added Cristiano Ronaldo to increase attacking output. But the underlying data suggests the team's more urgent issue was not chance creation. It was control: midfield stability, defensive transitions, and the ability to protect the back line.

> **United did not buy the wrong player as much as they bought the wrong solution. United added output when they needed control.**

2. EVIDENCE SNAPSHOT

	2020/21	2021/22
POINTS	74	58
XG DIFF / MATCH	+0.56	+0.01
XGA / MATCH	1.10	1.50
SHOTS AGAINST / MATCH	11.37	13.47

The decline was not only a table-position story: United lost most of their underlying xG cushion while conceding more chance quality and shot volume.

3. MODEL APPROACH

Using public match-level Premier League data, I modeled United's attacking and defensive profile through goals, xG, xGA, shots for, and shots against. A Poisson goal simulation then estimated win/draw/loss probabilities under alternative team profiles.

The counterfactual assumes no Ronaldo signing, with a control-oriented midfielder improving defensive stability and shot suppression.

This is a transparent scenario model, not causal proof.

4. COUNTERFACTUAL RESULT

2021/22 Points Scenario. Control improves the expected points profile, but does not transform the team.

The team tried to raise its ceiling, but failed to protect its floor.

Analytical caution: This is a directional scenario model. The uplift depends on assumptions, but the diagnosis remains stable across mild/base/strong cases.

5. REQUIRED MIDFIELDER PROFILE

A control-oriented midfielder should:

- receive under pressure
- progress play safely
- reduce central transition exposure
- protect rest defence
- improve territorial stability
- prevent defensive duels before they happen

> **The next signing should not only win duels. It should prevent some of them from happening.**

6. DECISION TAKEAWAY

Before buying output, diagnose the constraint.

Data should not just measure performance after the fact; it should help define the problem before capital is deployed.

Source: OGS counterfactual project outputs; public match-level Premier League data.